

Setting the tone: Nikhat Zareen became the first Indian boxer to confirm a Paris 2024 Olympic quota by punching her way past Jordan's Hanan Nassar at the Hangzhou Asian Games last year. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

doctor's recommendations for the prescribed rest days and any necessary measures. Ahlawat has served his stipulated 30-day suspension and has returned to the camp.

In the women's section, the rivalry between Commonwealth Games bronze medallist Jaismine Lamboria and Olympian Simranjit Kaur (60 kg) has grown over the years. The contest between two former World youth champions — Arundhati Choudhary, who came down from 75kg, and Ankushita Boro — has become more intense in 66kg.

Indian boxers will get two chances, in World Qualification Tournaments 1 and 2, from February 29 to March 12 and May 23 to June 3, respectively, to win quota places for the Olympics.

The next six to eight months will see earnest preparations from the pugilists in search of rare Olympic glory.

As the qualification process is still ongoing, it's premature to predict the difficulty of Indian boxers securing a medal in the Paris Olympics.

The participation of Russian and Belarusian athletes in the remaining two qualifying events could impact the odds, especially in weight categories where they excelled in the last World Championships.

Despite limited competition and some rustiness, boxers from these nations achieved notable success in the men's and women's World championships, securing a total of six (Russia 6) and four (Russia 3, Belarus 1) medals, respectively.

While lesser-known Russians claimed bronze in lighter weights, Olympic silver medallist Muslim Gadzhimagomedov (who claimed his second World title in heavyweight) impressed in the heavier categories for men. In the



IN TOKYO OLYMPICS, INDIA HAD NINE ENTRIES, AND BFI WOULD AIM FOR A SIMILAR NUMBER THIS TIME

women's event, Anastasiia Demurchian secured the light middleweight title, and Russians garnered more medals in heavier weights. If boxers from these two countries are allowed in the qualifiers, then it will be interesting to see how they fit into different Olympic weight classes and perform there.

In the backdrop of the turmoil in the International Boxing Association (IBA) due to its longstanding tussle with the International Olympic Committee (IOC) over various issues related to governance and eventual

termination, the BFI, with the help of the Sports Authority of India (SAI), has continued its boxing activities unabated. Overall, Indian boxers are getting fine exposure, including multi-nation camps and customised training. They need to get rid of their shortcomings and lift their game to strike it rich in the qualifiers as well as at the Olympics. Three Olympic bronze medals — Vijender Singh and Mary Kom's historic podium finishes in 2008 and 2012, respectively, and Lovlina's medal in 2021 — should motivate the Indian boxers.